



EDUCATION ABROAD PROGRAM

Re-entry Planning

The re-entry stage of the education abroad experience must not be overlooked. Although the activity of education abroad may be over, participants are still integrating and reflecting on their experiences. To fully complete the experiential learning cycle and adhere to the *Standards of Good Practice*, it is important to invest the time and resources available to your institution to provide opportunities for reflection among learners (Kolb, 1984)¹.

Creating a foundation prior to education abroad participation is key to preparing participants for meaningful and reflective re-entry upon return. Additionally, as participants are starting to move beyond the education abroad office, a successful re-entry strategy is dependent on partnerships with academic departments, career and professional resources, as well as student support services such as wellness centers, affinity resource centers, and community members.

APPLYING THE STANDARDS

*Standard 6.3. Student Learning and Development After Program: Responsible parties **shall** support post-program integration of academic, professional, and personal learning.*

Integrating Academic Learning

The education abroad experience is an academic endeavor. Whether participants are on faculty-led programs, taking classes abroad, conducting research, or participating in a guided internship experience, the activity is grounded in learning and the achievement of knowledge.

Regardless of a participant's academic preparation, major course of study, length of time abroad, activity undertaken abroad, or faculty engagement in education abroad, education abroad offices can enhance students' integration of learning into their academic experience.

1 Kolb, D. A. (1984). *Experiential learning: Experience as a source of learning and development*. Prentice-Hill

Questions to consider:

1. Is education abroad presented as an academic activity?
2. During the advising process, how are students advised to consider their academic trajectory?
3. Do students articulate their academic goals prior to education abroad?
4. How are faculty or academic advisors engaged in the advising and pre-departure process?
5. Are there any specific plans for how academic departments on your campus may or will follow up with returning students?

The integration of academic learning on education abroad does require collaboration among academic departments and faculty. Identifying supportive departments and faculty to encourage participants to continue their academic engagement is necessary for success.

Use the space provided below to identify departments or faculty supporting education abroad. An example is provided in *italics*:

Department	Faculty	How can they support returning education abroad students?
<i>Biology</i>	<i>Professor Micro Scope</i>	<i>Offers an upper-level course on the impact of global climate change. Encourage returning students to enroll.</i>

Integrating Professional Learning

Some education abroad experiences are more career-focused than others, such as internships and research. At the same time, education abroad is associated with the development of soft skills desired by employers. Providing participants with the appropriate terminology prior to departure, on-site, and upon return will provide a clearer perception of the potential connections between education abroad and professional planning.

Questions to consider:

1. How are participants encouraged to consider how education abroad fits into their career trajectory?
2. Does the education abroad portfolio include opportunities to explore specific career paths?
3. What structured opportunities are there for participants to engage with career or professional services staff upon return?
4. Are students introduced to career skills terminology before, during, and after their time abroad?
5. Are there formal opportunities for participants to present their education abroad gains (e.g., knowledge, experience, skills, values, connections, etc.) through their applications and interviews for jobs or graduate schools as well as through their online profiles, e.g., LinkedIn?
6. Are there opportunities for participants to practice articulating their newly-gained transferable skills through mock interviews, presentations, or other means?

Partnering with career and professional centers on your campus is critical to providing opportunities for participants to consider how education abroad fits into their professional planning. Career services professionals can provide returnees with career discernment strategies, self-assessments, networking support, advice on integrating education abroad into a resume, and access to career search engines where they can target organizations based on their previous and recently-gained experiences and skills.

Education abroad offices can also provide space for returnees to leverage new skills and enthusiasm for education abroad within their own teams. Ambassador programs, marketing internships, peer advising opportunities, whether paid or volunteer, help participants hone elevator pitches, personal branding, communication skills, and experience working in a professional environment.

Use the table below to map out activities that provide opportunities for returnees to explore professional growth after education abroad:

Activity	Description	Education Abroad Skills Leveraged
<i>Education Abroad Ambassador</i>	<i>Promotes education abroad through campus-wide presentations, tabling, and events such as the Education Abroad Fair</i>	<i>Communication (verbal), time management, project management, teamwork, problem solving</i>

Leveraging an education abroad experience for career planning can also result in positive outcomes for the institution and the education abroad office. Articulating clear connections between education abroad and the ability to find gainful employment after graduation demonstrates a positive return on investment (ROI) for participants, their families, and institutional leadership.

Integrating Personal Learning

With education abroad, it truly takes a village. Returning from an intensive experience can result in intense emotions and soul-searching. Leverage the expertise of professionals within your community to assist students with the re-adjustment process, but also to encourage them to keep the experience alive, where and as appropriate.

Use the table below to identify partners in re-entry to support returning students

Partner Unit	Point of Contact	How they can support returning students
<i>Wellness Center</i>	<i>Licensed Counselor</i>	<i>Re-entry focused counseling services, informal group programming for returning students.</i>